

The Sound of Kubrick

*“However good our best film composers may be, they are not a Beethoven, a Mozart, or a Brahms. Why use music which is less good when there is such a multitude of great orchestral music available from the past and from our own time? . . . With a little more care and thought these temporary tracks can become the final score.”*¹ -- Stanley Kubrick

When Stanley Kubrick made this statement, he could not have known the full impact of his decision to incorporate existing classical compositions and popular songs into his films. But consider today’s films that feature pre-recorded popular songs - it might be impossible to ignore the interplay between lyric and on-screen action, particularly if the song is “in” the film as source music. Or, for those deeply interested in media, one might notice the historical aspects of a composition as relevant to a film’s plot or tone. It’s fairly commonplace in the modern era of film history for music and source scoring to enhance narrative, define character, and support film marketing, but, prior to the 1960s, the industry lacked consideration for the intellectual or creative implications of weaving an existing piece of “art” into the textual fabric of a film. Kubrick’s interest in film scoring with pre-existing music primed him to exploit the potential, stretching the limit of film music beyond background filler or psychological enhancement. He understood the subtextual richness of using historically notable classical compositions in his narratives; his use of Beethoven motifs in *A Clockwork Orange* and Richard Strauss’s tone poem *Also sprach Zarathustra* in *2001: A Space Odyssey* both underscore his fascination with intertextuality² in media as the backgrounds of the songs themselves bear some relevance on the themes of the films. However, it is the cleverly ironic juxtapositions of music and action - most evident in *Dr. Strangelove*, *2001: A Space Odyssey*, *A Clockwork Orange*, and *Full Metal Jacket* - that elevate Kubrick’s use of music far beyond the typical functions of music in film, maximize the psychological impact of his visuals, and influence the future of filmmaking; author Philip Kuberski describes this synthesis of music and film aptly as “a repertoire of musical citation.”³

Kubrick is primarily known for psychologically impactful visuals and narratives; from ghostly apparitions and blood-filled hotel elevators to an “ultraviolent” future Britain, his films explore uncomfortable, vulnerable, and often dystopian landscapes. His vast capacity for satirizing the sharp corners of existence - grief, terror, irony, and the macabre - in order to effectively draw attention to their poignancy, Kubrick tightly controlled all aspects of filmmaking. His experience with filmmaking dates all the way back to a childhood

¹ Ciment, Michel. *Kubrick: The Definitive Edition*, trans. Gilbert Adair (New York: Faber and Faber, 1999), 177.

² Intertextuality is the mutual relationship or exchange between a text (in this case a film) with another text or texts (a musical composition) that become foundational to understanding or expanding upon the first; in essence, the texts are “woven” together.

³ Kuberski, Philip. *Kubrick’s Total Cinema : Philosophical Themes and Formal Qualities*. Continuum, 2012, 103.

interest in photography; born in 1928 in New York City, he briefly attended City College in the mid 1940s, ultimately leaving academia behind to become a photographer for *Look* magazine. He was hired at RKO-Pathé to make short films only a few years later, and 1956 marked his official entrance into Hollywood with the release of *The Killing*. Disillusioned with the constraints of the Hollywood system, Kubrick opted to depart for England in 1961 in order to continue making his films his way. Despite leaving the American industry due to its stale conventions and oppressive studio system, his subversive film content and methods of filmmaking still shaped (and continue to shape) American film history, contributing to the rise of the New Hollywood era in the mid 1960s which embraced upending and reinventing filmmaking conventions for a new generation of audiences and creators. Kubrick's structured methodology and understanding of film was influenced by Sergei Eisenstein and Vsevolod Pudovkin, both proponents of montage theory⁴, and he admired the work of fellow auteurs Ingmar Bergman and Federico Fellini⁵. His directorial style was also influenced by Sergei Eisenstein, another montage theorist and soviet film director; in theory and in practice, he was an introverted, detail-oriented, perfectionist who exerted a great deal of creative control over all aspects of his films - research, cinematography, editing, writing, staging, exhibition, marketing, and, most importantly for this essay, scoring.

His interest in film scoring began during his time at RKO; for his first short, *Day of the Fight* (1951), he hired a friend from his youth, Gerald Fried, a Juilliard graduate who had never scored a film. Rather than allow his newly christened composer to work autonomously, Kubrick joined Fried in studying films to examine how and why those films used music in the way they did, giving him a great deal of early insight into the functions of music in film. They collaborated until *Paths of Glory* (1957; the crux of their separation hinged on their personal thoughts about the use of pre-written music: Fried considered it antithetical to the illusion of the film world, while, as he says in the quote featured at the beginning of this essay, Kubrick saw pre-written music as an invaluable asset with great potential to enhance his work. They parted ways amicably and Kubrick went on to make *Spartacus* (1960), scored by Alex North, before establishing his new paradigm of using a combination of original music and pre-written music (and sometimes relying more heavily on the pre-written music for theme) to support narrative or enhance emotional affect of a film. The use of pre-written music was already a filmmaking convention at this time - the early days of film employed pre-composed mood libraries for quick and efficient scoring, temp tracks were and are still used to enhance early edits of a film, and, thanks to *Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid* (1969) and the New Hollywood movement, studios and filmmakers noted the commercial and subversive potency of inserting well-known pop songs into original narrative films.

Although *Dr. Strangelove* (1964) does feature original scoring provided by Alex North, it is the first film to fully utilize this ironic-music phenomenon with Vera Lynn's "We'll Meet Again" layered over the final scenes of the film. The film's narrative is a darkly satirical portrait of American cold-war era paranoia;

⁴ Montage theory posits that editing is the most integral part of filmmaking and is what imbues a scene with meaning.

⁵ Fellini, like Kubrick, deeply appreciated the potential of media intertextuality; for the duration of his career, he collaborated with composer Nino Rota, who incorporated pre-written compositions including circus music, American pop and jazz songs, and nationalistic Italian anthems into Fellini's films, all of which weave into the narratives or inform the characters in some way.

immature war-play consummates in total destruction as a soldier, Major Kong, rides a nuclear bomb down to earth⁶, waving his hat around like a true American cowboy riding off to manifest our collective destiny. The first explosion then cuts to the War Room, where political madmen continue their pointless games - espionage, political grandstanding - and Dr. Strangelove, a former Nazi scientist working for the Americans, stands up out of his wheelchair, cries “Mein Fuhrer!” and is suddenly revitalized by the fact they have “won” as the aggressors, and is so revitalized by this fact he is able to stand up out of his wheelchair for the first time in the film. However, his sudden potency and victory celebration are all for naught; the scene immediately cuts to a montage of mushroom clouds, over which Vera Lynn’s “We’ll Meet Again” plays⁷ sweetly in the nondiegetic background. The juxtaposition of assured nuclear destruction, petty and childish men who continue to be petty and childish in their last moments, and the bittersweet-yet-hopeful melody with lyrics “We’ll meet again / don’t know where / don’t know when / but I know we’ll meet again / some sunny day” seems to suggest that we are destined to repeat the same exact cycle of violence in our endless quest for political power and security - we have learned nothing and it is worth drawing attention so we might learn *something*. As the song goes on, images of mushroom clouds continue in succession, even including views from the uppermost atmosphere, in which it becomes evident that our thirst for bigger, better, stronger, more powerful is so vast it all but guarantees our inevitable self-destruction.

Four years after *Dr. Strangelove*, Kubrick released one of the most iconic sci-fi films of all time, *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968), based on Arthur C. Clarke’s novel of the same name. At the time, much of the discussion about the film’s music centered on tension between Alex North, who wrote an original score for Kubrick, and Kubrick’s own use of a temp track that later became the permanent track: Richard Strauss’ tone poem “Also sprach Zarathustra”. For many film audiences this music has become inseparable from the film; Johann Strauss II’s “Blue Danube Waltz” also features heavily in the film and is nearly impossible to hear without visualizing the Discovery One spaceship floating through space. Interestingly, Kubrick wanted a great deal of silence throughout the film, although there are two pieces of diegetic music in the film: an astronaut sings happy birthday to their child, and a computer sings Harry Dacre’s “Daisy Bell (Bicycle Built for Two)”⁸. This computer, HAL, manages all technology aboard the spaceship, but begins to malfunction and kill the men on board. Surviving astronaut Dave Bowman attempts to shut HAL’s system down; as HAL queries repeatedly - “What are you doing, Dave?” - Dave continues to turn off his operating system. As HAL loses “intelligence” via removal of various drives, he begins to tell Dave about his history and then sings Dacre’s “Daisy Bell”. The song is very simple in both melody and lyric, and it underscores HAL’s increasing simplicity of mind; it provides a contrast between the visible glossy technology aboard Discovery One, HAL’s previous machinations, and its reversion to simple, child-like processes of thought. It also references a real-life event; a few years

⁶ [AtomBomb1](#)

⁷ [AtomBomb2](#)

⁸  Deactivation of Hal 9000

before the making of this film, IBM programmed an early computer at Bell Labs with this song to demonstrate the computer's capacity for artificial speech.

Kubrick's next film was starkly different from the promising optimism of 2001's monolith. He adapted Anthony Burgess' *A Clockwork Orange* to film, and, like all of his adaptations, added dimensions of sound and visuals that enhance the original source story. Released in 1971, it is a violent portrait of a future Britain in which the main character, Alex, joyfully commits hedonistic acts of "ultraviolence" in between worshipping Beethoven and generally being a typically angsty and egocentric adolescent. Beethoven's music features prominently in the story itself, as he is both a source of Alex's pleasure, and, later, it is used in a behavioral conditioning treatment to engender a strong avoidance response; when it is played for him after this therapy, it is no longer a source of ecstasy but one of painful revulsion. Another piece of music, "Singin' in the Rain", stands out amidst the violence and timeless classical music; during one particularly violent scene early in the film, Alex and his friends break into the Alexanders' home and thoroughly abuse them both. Alex sings an a capella version of the song⁹ and matches the rhythm with emphatic kicking and torture of his victims. Despite the song's cheery and optimistic sound and associations through film history¹⁰, here it draws attention to the violence; the pulse and melody are woven into the violence through source scoring, forcing the viewer to engage emotionally. The violence is alienating, but the song is enshrined in media culture; this creates what scholar Peter Hoyng calls an "ambiguity of violence" and "conflicted semiotics"¹¹. Audiences would also have associated this song with the popular and very non-violent 1952 film featuring Gene Kelly; Alex's choreographed violence mirrors Kelly's choreographed song and dance in *Singin' in the Rain*. In this film, the song generates a swirling discomfort as we are pushed away by the visual and pulled closer by the music's familiarity.

In the years following *A Clockwork Orange*, Kubrick released *Barry Lyndon* and ended the decade with *The Shining* in 1980; both films feature conscientious music choices, but rely more on originality and subtlety of the familiar. However, by the end of the 1980s, he was back to the previous paradigm with *Full Metal Jacket* (1987). This film offers a critical and intimate view of the Vietnam War; the film begins with boot camp, where one of their fellow recruits just can't cut it, goes mad, and takes his life. It switches to the action on the ground, which ranges from war operations, infighting, interacting with locals, and ends with the soldier marching through the dark, surrounded by flames and destruction. Throughout the film are several pop songs; in many ways they not only create time and place, but reference the media aspect of the Vietnam War itself; it became its own kind of series of cultural signs and representations through media, essentially lending itself to a dimension of pop culture. During the ending scenes, the "Mickey Mouse Club March" plays¹²; the soldiers are actually

⁹  A Clockwork Orange Singing in the rain Scene

¹⁰ The song was written by Arthur Freed and Nacio Brown, and was featured on Broadway in The Hollywood Revue of 1929. It was popular during this time and Freed himself used his own catalogue, including this song, as inspiration for the film of the same name.

¹¹ Hoyng, Peter. "Ambiguities of Violence in Beethoven's Ninth through the Eyes of Stanley Kubrick's *A Clockwork Orange*." *The German Quarterly*, vol. 84, no. 2, 2011, pp. 171, <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1756-1183.2011.00109.x>.

¹²  Full Metal Jacket - Mickey Mouse song

singing it as they march through a desolate flaming wasteland of their own making. The militaristic rhythm of the song is appropriate for the soldiers, however the lyrics and cultural associations of the song obviously mean something different. Rather than a parade of consumerism and commodification like one might find at Disneyworld's Main Street, here is a different kind of parade; the consumption is not of imagination but rather lives, culture, the men's sanity, and Vietnam itself. The juxtaposition of the war machine against one of America's most capitalist enterprises suggests an interesting dichotomy of American life; we control through war and we control through culture. The men continue singing this song, even emphasizing changes in pitch associated with the real song, as Private Davis delivers a voiceover that drives home the ugliness of their war experience. The song's melody and lyrics conjure Hoyng's "conflicted semiotics" yet again. Kubrick himself wanted to draw attention to the war machine and even said "...in America every child sits in front of his television set singing that song and what I wanted to suggest in that was that these boys [the soldiers] are only just a few years past sitting in front of the TV set, children singing Mickey Mouse... When you realize that an 18 year old boy is only 6 or 7 years away from being a child."¹³ In that context, it becomes even more impactful, underscoring the American war machine's propensity for turning young men into soldiers.

Essentially, Kubrick was able to weave these implications and associations into the narrative without dialogue, juxtaposing pop tunes with cheery associations and implications alongside stark images of violence, war, and technological failure. The effect of these ironies and contrasts is an amplified emotional and intellectual engagement as the viewer's attention is drawn not only to what is seen on screen but to lyrics, familiar sounds with familiar associations; those familiar sounds and associations profoundly contrast the visual aspects to the extent the meaning "whole" becomes greater than the meaning of the individual parts. Irony in particular draws attention as it forces acknowledgement of a friction or incongruity that goes entirely against convention and expectation. This ironic function of film music is used so often today it has even lost some of its power to call attention to meaning; however, when Kubrick began using music in this way several decades ago, he was perhaps the first to do so to the extent it reframes the narrative and adjusts viewer expectations. Additionally, his overall use of music in film relayed a considerable understanding of how music can be incorporated into a film for more profound functions beyond mood and filler: his use of Beethoven as a motif in *Clockwork Orange* as well as his use of 2001's well-known Straussian theme "Also sprach Zarathustra"¹⁴ enhanced the films' narratives by offering subtextual implications and connections that add an analytical richness to them. For *Barry Lyndon*, Kubrick's choices for music included reinterpretations of Irish folk song¹⁵ to both satirize and enhance political and nationalistic contexts of narrative and characters. His last film, *Eyes Wide Shut*, is more restrained in its use of music, but still features pieces from composers Franz Liszt and Mozart. Unfortunately he passed away only a few days after presenting a special screening of the film to his

¹³ McQuiston, Kate. *We'll Meet Again : Musical Design in the Films of Stanley Kubrick*. Oxford University Press, 2013, p. 31.

¹⁴  2001: A Space Odyssey • Theme/Also Sprach Zarathustra • Richard Strauss

¹⁵  Barry Lyndon - Irish Jig

family and friends. In spite of his death, ripples of his influence and innovation in storytelling and cinematography are evident everywhere in filmmaking today. Kubrick's contributions to music in film showed music's greatly enhanced potential for driving storytelling; although he was not a musician, his appreciation for music demonstrated its effectiveness, as evidenced by his powerful execution of ironic contrast of media.

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